ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Manufacturing English

Conversation lab

8 complete workplace dialogues, followed by eight additional role-play cases. Study the exchanges, then make the conversation your own.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

Open this course on English Ladder

Inside this conversation lab

Original fictional training conversations in professional English. These are realistic scripts, not transcripts of actual people. The professional roles are the speaker labels; all figures, incidents, and organizations are invented.

Then try eight independent role-play cases, followed by feedback criteria and references.

Read it. Hear it. Make it yours.

1. Read the setting. Identify the roles, the immediate problem, and what each speaker needs.

2. Read the whole conversation aloud with a partner. In a group, give a third person the observer role. For three-speaker scripts, assign each professional a separate voice.

3. Notice how the speakers ask a specific question, qualify a claim, disagree, explain a technical point, or agree on a next step. Underline language you would actually use.

4. Cover the script. Recreate the exchange using the situation and professional roles. Keep the meaning, but change the wording.

5. Switch roles and introduce a complication: a missing record, a different priority, an unavailable colleague, or a changed assumption. End with a clear outcome or unresolved question.

Register and terminology

These colleagues use concise professional language. In an internal technical meeting, familiar abbreviations can be natural. With a new colleague or a client, expand unfamiliar terms and check understanding. Keep disagreement directed at the evidence or proposal, and match the degree of certainty to what is known.

Independent study

Speak each role aloud. Pause before the reply and supply your own response before revealing the next line. Record a second version using invented details, then compare its clarity and tone with the script.

Professional context

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

FULL DIALOGUE 01 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Morning tier meeting

The packaging line has missed its hourly production target.

Roles: Production supervisor / Line leader / Maintenance technician

Production supervisor: We're 160 units behind plan. Where are we losing time?

Line leader: At the case sealer. We've had four short stops since startup.

Maintenance technician: Is it the same fault code each time?

Line leader: Yes, the infeed sensor. Operators logged each stop on the downtime sheet.

Production supervisor: Can we recover the schedule without adding a second shift?

Maintenance technician: I need to inspect the sensor under the approved isolation procedure before estimating downtime.

Line leader: I'll separate the affected cases and update the hour-by-hour board.

Production supervisor: Good. Maintenance owns the fault check; I'll revise the production plan after your assessment.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "We're 160 units behind plan. Where are we losing time?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 02 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Changeover improvement

A production team reviews a lengthy product changeover.

Roles: Continuous improvement engineer / Setup technician

Continuous improvement engineer: The changeover took 52 minutes. Which steps required the machine to be stopped?

Setup technician: Tooling adjustment and first-piece approval. We also spent ten minutes finding the change parts.

Continuous improvement engineer: Could we stage those parts before shutdown?

Setup technician: Yes, but the kit needs a check sheet. Two guides look almost identical.

Continuous improvement engineer: Let's trial a labeled changeover cart on the next run.

Setup technician: Keep the first-piece inspection in the sequence. That's not time we can simply remove.

Continuous improvement engineer: Agreed. We'll measure searching time separately from adjustment and inspection.

Setup technician: I'll prepare the kit and record anything missing before the trial.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The changeover took 52 minutes. Which steps required the machine to be stopped?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 03 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Scrap versus rework

Quality and production review scratched housings.

Roles: Quality engineer / Production supervisor

Quality engineer: The inspection report shows 24 scratched housings. Are all 24 scrap?

Production supervisor: Not yet. Six look suitable for rework, but we haven't received a disposition.

Quality engineer: Keep the entire group identified and segregated until that review is complete.

Production supervisor: Can we count the six toward today's good output?

Quality engineer: Only after approved rework and acceptance. They aren't conforming units yet.

Production supervisor: Understood. I'll report 24 on hold, with six proposed for rework.

Quality engineer: I'll check the acceptance criteria and document the disposition.

Production supervisor: Send the approved instructions to the line leader before we start.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "The inspection report shows 24 scratched housings. Are all 24 scrap?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 04 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Recurring dimensional defect

A team investigates an out-of-tolerance bore.

Roles: Quality engineer / Process engineer

Quality engineer: The bore diameter is drifting toward the upper limit again.

Process engineer: Tool wear is my leading hypothesis, but the gauge readings need checking.

Quality engineer: The operator says the gauge was dropped yesterday.

Process engineer: Then let's verify the measurement system before changing the offset.

Quality engineer: What happens to the parts produced since the last accepted check?

Process engineer: We'll identify that interval and ask quality to define containment.

Quality engineer: I'll arrange the gauge check and preserve the inspection records.

Process engineer: I'll compare tool life and machine history. We shouldn't close the corrective action on a guess.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What happens to the parts produced since the last accepted check?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 05 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Preventive maintenance window

Maintenance and planning negotiate access to a bottleneck machine.

Roles: Maintenance planner / Production planner

Maintenance planner: The press is due for preventive maintenance this week. I need a four-hour window.

Production planner: Thursday's schedule is full. Could we move it into next month?

Maintenance planner: I can't approve an extension. The reliability engineer needs to assess that request.

Production planner: What about Friday after the priority order?

Maintenance planner: That could work if the spare seals arrive and we have the right technician.

Production planner: I'll reserve a provisional slot and flag the dependency on parts.

Maintenance planner: I'll confirm parts availability by tomorrow's planning meeting.

Production planner: Then we'll release the revised schedule once the maintenance window is confirmed.

Notice the professional language

preventive maintenance - Planned work intended to reduce failures and maintain equipment condition.

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 06 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

A safety concern on the line

An operator reports a damaged guard before startup.

Roles: Machine operator / Shift supervisor

Machine operator: The guard latch isn't engaging. I haven't started the machine.

Shift supervisor: Thanks for stopping. Keep it out of service while we get maintenance involved.

Machine operator: The previous shift said it sometimes catches on the second attempt.

Shift supervisor: That doesn't establish that it's safe. We'll follow the equipment isolation and reporting procedure.

Machine operator: Should I log it as a breakdown or a safety concern?

Shift supervisor: Record the guard defect and the actual condition; I'll make sure both teams receive it.

Machine operator: I'll hand the job sheet to the maintenance lead.

Shift supervisor: I'll reassign the work and confirm who authorizes a return to service.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Should I log it as a breakdown or a safety concern?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 07 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Incoming material discrepancy

Receiving finds different material identification on a delivery.

Roles: Receiving inspector / Supplier quality engineer

Receiving inspector: The purchase order specifies grade 304, but these labels say 316.

Supplier quality engineer: Does the certificate of analysis match the labels or the order?

Receiving inspector: The certificate says 316. The delivery note says 304.

Supplier quality engineer: Put the delivery on hold. We need traceability back to the supplier's batch.

Receiving inspector: Production is asking whether the higher grade is automatically acceptable.

Supplier quality engineer: A different grade needs engineering review; we can't substitute it ourselves.

Receiving inspector: I'll photograph the labels and send the batch numbers.

Supplier quality engineer: I'll raise the supplier discrepancy and request a corrected explanation and documents.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "Does the certificate of analysis match the labels or the order?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

FULL DIALOGUE 08 / 8 SPEAKING TURNS

Shift handover

The incoming supervisor takes over a partly completed order.

Roles: Outgoing supervisor / Incoming supervisor

Outgoing supervisor: Order 418 is running, but pallet seven is on quality hold.

Incoming supervisor: What's the reason, and which units are affected?

Outgoing supervisor: A missing inspection entry. The hold tag lists serial numbers 601 through 624.

Incoming supervisor: Have those units been moved to the hold area?

Outgoing supervisor: Yes. Quality has the record; no disposition yet.

Incoming supervisor: So the remaining pallets can follow the normal release process, but pallet seven stays held.

Outgoing supervisor: Correct. The line also needs new labels before the next order.

Incoming supervisor: I'll follow up with quality and verify the label change at setup.

Notice the professional language

Discuss this wording: "What's the reason, and which units are affected?" What does it help the other professional clarify?

Rehearse and extend with AI

Explain the issue and the agreed next step without reading. Identify any point still awaiting evidence, agreement, or approval. Then replay the exchange with a changed constraint and a new ending.

Observer: note one natural professional expression and one place where the follow-up made the meaning clearer.

Eight more situations to make your own

The following cases are open role plays. They give you facts, contrasting roles, useful expressions, and a short model response. Use what you learned from the complete dialogues to create a longer exchange.

Preparation: two minutes. Conversation: three to five minutes. Feedback: one minute. Switch roles and repeat with the second-round challenge.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 01

Production Flow and Daily Management

SHARED CASE

A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Role A | Responding professional

Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Useful expressions

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is ... .

The next update will cover ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

Second round

The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 02

Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

SHARED CASE

A team observes repeated waiting for shared tools during a kaizen event. A supervisor blames slow operators.

Role A | Responding professional

Describe observed behavior, its effect, and a useful next step. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Useful expressions

In [specific situation], I noticed ... .

The effect was ... . What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Cover this until after your first attempt

The observed delay occurs while people wait for shared tools. Let's examine tool availability and layout before attributing the issue to individual speed. Could we test a revised arrangement?

Second round

The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 03

Defects, Scrap, and Rework

SHARED CASE

A quality report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework. The manager needs to understand the different consequences.

Role A | Responding professional

Explain a useful distinction in plain English. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Useful expressions

In this context, ... means ... .

The difference is that ... .

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Scrap and rework are different outcomes. Scrapped units will not return to the process as usable product; rework attempts to make units conform. I'll report their quantities separately.

Second round

Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 04

Root Cause and Corrective Action

SHARED CASE

A defect appears after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed. A team member names the supplier as the root cause.

Role A | Responding professional

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Useful expressions

The available evidence shows ... .

This may indicate ..., but ... .

We have not yet established whether ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

The timing makes the supplier change worth examining, but other settings changed too. It is a hypothesis, not an established root cause. Let's compare the evidence before closing the investigation.

Second round

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 05

Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

SHARED CASE

A planned maintenance window conflicts with a rush order. The maintenance team needs to explain the available options to the decision maker.

Role A | Responding professional

Negotiate scope or timing while making conditions explicit. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Useful expressions

We can ..., provided that ... .

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

The rush order and maintenance window compete for the same equipment. Could we review the approved options, expected production impact, and reliability concerns together before changing the plan?

Second round

The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 06

EHS and Safety Communication

SHARED CASE

During a safety exercise, a learner notices an unclear equipment-isolation instruction. The local approved procedure must govern the work.

Role A | Responding professional

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Useful expressions

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

I need clarification of this instruction before the task proceeds. Please involve the authorized person and use the approved safety procedure. I will point out exactly which instruction is unclear.

Second round

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 07

Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

SHARED CASE

An incoming inspection report cites a dimension without identifying the drawing revision. The supplier used a different revision.

Role A | Responding professional

Clarify missing information before responding. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Useful expressions

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is ... . Is that right?

Cover this until after your first attempt

Which drawing revision applies to this delivery? Let's record both references and ask the responsible quality team to resolve the discrepancy before we describe the material as conforming.

Second round

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

ROLE-PLAY CASE 08

Shift Handoffs and Escalation

SHARED CASE

The outgoing shift has completed six of eight checks. Two checks remain open, with records attached and a named incoming supervisor.

Role A | Responding professional

Give a handoff that the receiving person can confirm. Use only the facts given. Choose two relevant terms and be ready to explain one of them in ordinary words.

Role B | Listener

You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Useful expressions

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is ... .

The record shows ... .

Please confirm who has accepted ... .

Cover this until after your first attempt

Six checks are complete; two remain open. The records show what has been checked and what is pending. Please confirm that the incoming supervisor has accepted the follow-up tasks.

Second round

The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Debrief and extend with AI

Which phrase helped the listener? Which case fact needed clarification? Write one better follow-up question, then repeat the exchange.

Lesson conversations and speaking practice

The following sections match 05 and 06 on the industry webpage and in the learner workbook. Each lesson has three ten-turn conversations and two bounded speaking scenarios. These are original fictional teaching scripts, not transcripts of real people.

LESSON 01 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A 160-unit gap with downtime still under review

Fictional daily production meeting: the line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target; 40 minutes of downtime are logged, but the cause is unconfirmed.

01 · Production supervisor: We produced eight hundred forty units against a thousand-unit target, leaving a gap of one hundred sixty.

02 · Operations manager: Does the forty minutes of downtime explain the entire gap to target?

03 · Production supervisor: That hasn't been established. Downtime is recorded, but its cause and contribution are still under review.

04 · Operations manager: What can we report as completed work rather than an assumption about the constraint?

05 · Production supervisor: The output count and downtime duration are confirmed. The explanation for the shortfall remains pending.

06 · Operations manager: Should we promise to recover all one hundred sixty units during the next shift?

07 · Production supervisor: Not without assessing capacity and the unresolved issue. I can request a recovery-plan review.

08 · Operations manager: Please include cycle-time evidence if it helps explain the actual throughput limitation.

09 · Production supervisor: I'll bring the verified log and separate measured performance from proposed explanations.

10 · Operations manager: Good. We'll review the next update before committing to a recovery quantity or naming the cause.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A queue grows between assembly and inspection

Separate fictional production case: assembly completed 120 units, inspection completed 90, and 30 newly assembled units await inspection; no earlier queue is included.

01 · Line leader: Assembly completed one hundred twenty units, and inspection completed ninety from this group.

02 · Production planner: Then can I describe all one hundred twenty as finished output for dispatch?

03 · Line leader: No. Thirty still await inspection, so assembly completion is not the same as dispatch readiness.

04 · Production planner: Does that prove inspection is our permanent production constraint rather than a temporary queue?

05 · Line leader: Not from this snapshot. We need the process history and capacity information before making that conclusion.

06 · Production planner: I'll report the thirty-unit inspection queue separately from the completed inspection count.

07 · Line leader: Please keep the scope clear: these figures concern this group, not an earlier backlog.

08 · Production planner: Can you confirm the next inspection-status checkpoint before I update the downstream schedule?

09 · Line leader: I'll ask the inspection lead and return a verified update rather than estimate an unapproved release time.

10 · Production planner: Understood. I'll keep throughput stages distinct and avoid treating unfinished work as available inventory.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

The line restarted, but the loss is not explained

Separate fictional daily-management exercise: line B restarted at 11:10 after a 15-minute stop; the stop reason and lost-output estimate remain unverified.

01 · Shift supervisor: Line B restarted at eleven ten after a fifteen-minute stop. The cause is still being checked.

02 · Production analyst: Can I close the downtime investigation now that the line is running again?

03 · Shift supervisor: Restart is a confirmed operational status, not a completed explanation of the stop.

04 · Production analyst: Should I calculate lost output using yesterday's cycle time as though it applied today?

05 · Shift supervisor: Only as an explicitly labeled estimate if appropriate; today's actual conditions haven't been verified here.

06 · Production analyst: I'll keep the confirmed duration separate from any proposed loss calculation.

07 · Shift supervisor: Good. Don't describe the restart as proof that the underlying constraint has disappeared permanently.

08 · Production analyst: What next update do you need for the afternoon daily-management discussion?

09 · Shift supervisor: The verified reason, relevant production conditions, and any remaining action owned by the responsible team.

10 · Production analyst: I'll gather those details and report completed recovery separately from the pending investigation.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 01 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Production Flow and Daily Management

A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Second round: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for scenario 1: Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

Scenario 2 | Output recorded in different units

A fictional morning board shows 60 boxes while the production target is 600 individual units. The number of units per box has not been confirmed. Give a status explanation and request the missing conversion before stating performance against target.

Role A: Production analyst: identify the measurement mismatch.

Role B: Shift leader: confirm the need to verify packing quantity before comparing output.

Possible opening: The board counts boxes, but the target counts individual units, so we need the verified conversion.

Success checks

- Keep the two measurement units distinct.

- Do not invent a conversion or performance result.

- Agree who verifies the pack quantity and updates the board.

Add a complication: A manager suggests assuming ten units per box because that was last month's format.

LESSON 02 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Waiting for shared tools, not slow operators

Fictional kaizen discussion: repeated waits for shared tools were observed, but the supervisor has described the operators as slow.

01 · Improvement facilitator: We observed repeated waiting for shared tools. Calling the operators slow doesn't describe that process problem.

02 · Production supervisor: What feedback would help the team without sounding like a personal criticism of my comment?

03 · Improvement facilitator: Say what happened: work paused while the tools were unavailable, which interrupted the observed flow.

04 · Production supervisor: Should we immediately buy another set and call the waste removed from the value stream?

05 · Improvement facilitator: We should examine the pattern and proposed change first. The observation doesn't establish the best solution.

06 · Production supervisor: I'll ask the team to show where the waiting occurs during the standard work.

07 · Improvement facilitator: Good. Invite their explanation of access and sequencing instead of assuming a motivation problem.

08 · Production supervisor: Then we can propose a small reviewed improvement and define what we will observe afterward.

09 · Improvement facilitator: Exactly. Kaizen feedback should connect the observed interruption to a practical next step.

10 · Production supervisor: I'll restate the issue as tool availability and keep any claim of improvement dependent on the follow-up evidence.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A long walk to the label printer

Separate fictional improvement case: an observer recorded six trips from packing to a shared label printer during one hour; distances and causes of repeat trips are unmeasured.

01 · Lean coordinator: I observed six trips to the label printer in one hour, interrupting the packing sequence.

02 · Packing supervisor: Are you saying the packers are walking too slowly between their tasks?

03 · Lean coordinator: No. My feedback concerns repeated travel in the process, not the speed or effort of individuals.

04 · Packing supervisor: Could we call moving the printer closer a confirmed time-saving change right away?

05 · Lean coordinator: It is an option to assess. We haven't measured distance, reasons for repeat trips, or the resulting time.

06 · Packing supervisor: I'll ask the packers which trips are necessary and where the standard work creates additional travel.

07 · Lean coordinator: Please use concrete examples so we can distinguish needed movement from possible waste.

08 · Packing supervisor: Then we'll discuss an appropriately reviewed layout trial and a clear comparison method.

09 · Lean coordinator: Good. Keep the observation separate from a promised improvement percentage.

10 · Packing supervisor: I'll bring the team's explanation to the kaizen discussion and agree how to evaluate any proposed change.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A handoff interrupts standard work

Separate fictional kaizen observation: an operator stopped the packing sequence twice to answer status questions already shown on the team's board.

01 · Team leader: I interrupted packing twice to ask for status that was already on the board.

02 · Improvement coach: That's a specific observation. What effect did those interruptions have on the standard-work sequence?

03 · Team leader: The operator stopped the sequence to answer me; I didn't measure the total delay.

04 · Improvement coach: Then describe the interruption without inventing a time loss or blaming the operator.

05 · Team leader: Could I try checking the board first and only ask when the status needs clarification?

06 · Improvement coach: That is a practical behavior to test, provided the board is kept current.

07 · Team leader: We haven't checked its update reliability yet, so I'll ask the team about that dependency.

08 · Improvement coach: Good. Continuous improvement should consider the information process as well as the individual interaction.

09 · Team leader: I'll explain what I observed and agree a trial for the next daily-management cycle.

10 · Improvement coach: Then review whether interruptions changed, without assuming the proposed habit eliminates all waste in the value stream.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 02 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

A team observes repeated waiting for shared tools during a kaizen event. A supervisor blames slow operators.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can explain a practical obstacle affecting the work. Share it after your partner asks for your perspective, then agree on one observable change.

Second round: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

Model for scenario 1: The observed delay occurs while people wait for shared tools. Let's examine tool availability and layout before attributing the issue to individual speed. Could we test a revised arrangement?

Scenario 2 | A suggestion dismissed before explanation

During a fictional kaizen meeting, a technician proposes moving a shared gauge. The supervisor replies that the team always complains before hearing the reason. Practice feedback on the interruption and invite the technician's process observation.

Role A: Improvement facilitator: describe the supervisor's actual remark and its effect on the discussion.

Role B: Production supervisor: acknowledge the interruption and propose a more useful follow-up question.

Possible opening: When the suggestion was called complaining before the reason was heard, we lost the chance to examine the process issue.

Success checks

- Use the supplied behavior rather than label the supervisor's character.

- Separate hearing a suggestion from approving a change.

- Agree a focused question about the observed workflow.

Add a complication: The supervisor says accepting feedback means agreeing to move the gauge immediately.

LESSON 03 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Scrap and pending rework are different outcomes

Fictional quality review: a report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework; separate quantities and final rework outcomes are not supplied.

01 · Production manager: The report groups scrap and pending rework together. Why does that distinction matter for planning?

02 · Quality engineer: Scrap isn't recovered usable output. Pending rework still needs corrective work and acceptance checks before it counts as usable.

03 · Production manager: Can we count every unit awaiting rework as recovered output when we forecast supply?

04 · Quality engineer: No. Pending rework is not completed rework or an accepted final result.

05 · Production manager: What should the report show without inventing separate quantities we don't yet have?

06 · Quality engineer: Request the separate counts and distinguish scrap, pending rework, and any verified accepted output.

07 · Production manager: Would the total defect count still be useful once those categories are separated?

08 · Quality engineer: Yes, but it answers a different question from available supply or the workload remaining.

09 · Production manager: I'll keep containment status visible and ask the team to reconcile the categories.

10 · Quality engineer: I'll provide the verified breakdown and avoid treating a proposed recovery path as a guaranteed production outcome.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Fifty units contained, five units confirmed defective

Separate fictional inspection case: 50 units are contained for review, with five units confirmed defective so far; inspection of the remaining 45 units is pending.

01 · Warehouse lead: We contained fifty units. Should the dashboard show fifty units confirmed defective?

02 · Quality inspector: No. Five units are confirmed defective, while the remaining forty-five units still await inspection.

03 · Warehouse lead: So containment defines the group held for review, not the number already found defective?

04 · Quality inspector: Exactly. It is important not to turn a precautionary scope into a confirmed defective-unit count.

05 · Warehouse lead: Could I release the other forty-five because no defect has been recorded for them yet?

06 · Quality inspector: No. Pending inspection is not a passing result or an authorized disposition.

07 · Warehouse lead: I'll show fifty contained, five confirmed defective, and forty-five inspection results pending.

08 · Quality inspector: Please keep those categories linked so the group isn't counted twice in the total.

09 · Warehouse lead: I'll request the next verified status before updating available inventory or rework planning.

10 · Quality inspector: I'll return the inspection and disposition information through the quality process without predicting how many will pass.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Rework finished, acceptance check not finished

Separate fictional production case: 18 units completed an authorized rework activity, but their subsequent acceptance checks have not been completed.

01 · Rework coordinator: The rework activity is finished for eighteen units. Can they count as accepted output?

02 · Quality reviewer: Their acceptance checks are still pending, so completion of rework doesn't establish final acceptance.

03 · Rework coordinator: Does that mean I should label all eighteen as scrap until inspection is finished?

04 · Quality reviewer: No. Pending acceptance and scrap are different statuses; don't replace one with the other.

05 · Rework coordinator: What wording best explains their current position in the production flow?

06 · Quality reviewer: Eighteen units reworked, awaiting acceptance checks. Keep availability conditional on the authorized outcome.

07 · Rework coordinator: I'll use that wording so planning sees both completed effort and remaining work.

08 · Quality reviewer: Good. It also prevents the reworked quantity from being mistaken for a confirmed recovery rate.

09 · Rework coordinator: Who should confirm the next status before the dispatch team makes a commitment?

10 · Quality reviewer: The responsible quality team will communicate the verified result and disposition through the established process.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 03 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Defects, Scrap, and Rework

A quality report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework. The manager needs to understand the different consequences.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are unfamiliar with one technical term in the case. Ask for a plain-English explanation and then paraphrase it. Do not pretend to understand a term you cannot explain.

Second round: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

Model for scenario 1: Scrap and rework are different outcomes. Scrapped units will not return to the process as usable product; rework attempts to make units conform. I'll report their quantities separately.

Scenario 2 | One unit with two defects

A fictional inspection finds two defects on one unit and one defect on a second unit. The report says three defective units. Discuss the difference between defect count and defective-unit count before the daily meeting.

Role A: Quality analyst: explain the two counting methods using the supplied observations.

Role B: Production supervisor: confirm the corrected unit count and ask how both measures should be labeled.

Possible opening: We found three defects across two units, not three defective units.

Success checks

- State three defects and two affected units accurately.
- Keep the measures distinct and avoid double counting.
- Do not infer scrap, rework, or release from defect count alone.

Add a complication: A colleague wants to add the two measures together into one total quality-loss number.

LESSON 04 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A supplier change is one hypothesis

Fictional root-cause review: a defect appeared after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed.

01 · Production engineer: The defect appeared after the supplier change. Can we name the supplier as the root cause?

02 · Quality lead: Not yet. Several process settings changed too, so timing alone doesn't isolate the cause.

03 · Production engineer: Would a fishbone diagram help us separate supplier and process explanations during the review?

04 · Quality lead: Yes, as a way to organize hypotheses, not as proof that any branch is correct.

05 · Production engineer: Could we use 5 Whys to force the discussion to end with one definite answer today?

06 · Quality lead: The questions should follow evidence. We shouldn't invent a causal chain to fill the template.

07 · Production engineer: I'll bring the change records and identify which conditions differed when the defect appeared.

08 · Quality lead: Please preserve the unknowns and distinguish immediate containment from a completed 8D investigation.

09 · Production engineer: Then the team can plan comparisons rather than assign blame from the sequence alone.

10 · Quality lead: Agreed. We'll state the supplier change as a hypothesis until the relevant evidence supports a conclusion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A repeated adjustment does not establish the cause

Separate fictional investigation: operators adjusted alignment after three separate defects, but no controlled comparison or verified cause exists.

01 · Maintenance analyst: Operators adjusted alignment after all three defects. Does that establish alignment as the root cause?

02 · Quality investigator: It establishes an action taken after the defects, not what originally caused them.

03 · Maintenance analyst: Could their repeated choice still be useful evidence for our fishbone discussion?

04 · Quality investigator: Yes. Ask what they observed and why they chose the adjustment, while keeping the explanation provisional.

05 · Maintenance analyst: Should we describe the adjustment as a confirmed corrective action in the 8D update?

06 · Quality investigator: Not as a proven cause-based solution. We need evidence of the relationship and effectiveness.

07 · Maintenance analyst: I'll preserve the action history without writing that the adjustment eliminated the defect.

08 · Quality investigator: Good. Also identify any other changes that accompanied the adjustment before interpreting the sequence.

09 · Maintenance analyst: I'll request those records and ask the operators for their observed findings.

10 · Quality investigator: Then we can examine the hypothesis without turning a repeated response into a demonstrated root cause.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A clean shift after a change is encouraging, not conclusive

Separate fictional corrective-action review: one shift reported no recurrence after a process change; only that shift's observation is available.

01 · Operations manager: We had no recurrence this shift. Can the corrective-action report say the problem is permanently solved?

02 · Quality engineer: One clean shift is an observation, but it doesn't establish permanent elimination of the cause.

03 · Operations manager: How should I acknowledge the encouraging result without overstating what it proves?

04 · Quality engineer: Say no recurrence was observed during that shift and describe the agreed effectiveness review as pending.

05 · Operations manager: Could we close the 8D simply because the change has been implemented?

06 · Quality engineer: Implementation and demonstrated effectiveness are different stages. Follow the established closure criteria.

07 · Operations manager: The case doesn't supply those criteria, so I shouldn't invent a required number of shifts.

08 · Quality engineer: Correct. Ask the action owner to confirm the applicable assessment plan.

09 · Operations manager: I'll report the limited observation and request the next review checkpoint from the owner.

10 · Quality engineer: I'll keep the evidence scope clear so a useful initial result doesn't become an unsupported universal claim.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 04 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Root Cause and Corrective Action

A defect appears after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed. A team member names the supplier as the root cause.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to tell a colleague what is known. Ask which part is confirmed and which part is an assumption. Challenge one statement that sounds more certain than the case supports.

Second round: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Model for scenario 1: The timing makes the supplier change worth examining, but other settings changed too. It is a hypothesis, not an established root cause. Let's compare the evidence before closing the investigation.

Scenario 2 | Two changed conditions in the successful trial

A fictional defect trial changed both material storage and machine setup; the trial produced no observed defects. The team wants to credit storage alone. Discuss what the trial can establish and what comparison remains needed.

Role A: Process engineer: describe both changed conditions and the observed result.

Role B: Quality investigator: challenge the single-cause conclusion and propose a reviewed evidence-gathering step.

Possible opening: Both storage and setup changed, so this result doesn't isolate storage as the cause.

Success checks

- Keep both changed conditions visible.

- Distinguish the observed trial result from a causal conclusion.

- Agree further assessment without prescribing an unsafe process experiment.

Add a complication: The meeting chair wants one root cause entered before lunch regardless of the evidence.

LESSON 05 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

A rush order overlaps planned maintenance

Fictional scheduling negotiation: a rush order overlaps a planned maintenance window; no authorization to defer maintenance or spare capacity is confirmed.

01 · Production planner: The rush order overlaps the maintenance window. Could we postpone preventive maintenance to finish the order?

02 · Maintenance lead: We need the authorized assessment first. I can't assume deferral is acceptable for this equipment.

03 · Production planner: What options can we bring to the decision maker without overriding that boundary?

04 · Maintenance lead: Assess the order timing, any verified alternate capacity, and the maintenance team's permitted scheduling options.

05 · Production planner: Could we promise another line while its capacity and changeover requirements are still unknown?

06 · Maintenance lead: No. Present that as an option requiring confirmation, not available capacity.

07 · Production planner: I'll ask sales which delivery flexibility exists and keep the maintenance dependency explicit.

08 · Maintenance lead: I'll request the authorized timing assessment and identify any spare-parts dependency affecting the window.

09 · Production planner: Then we'll compare confirmed options before offering the customer a revised commitment.

10 · Maintenance lead: Agreed. We can negotiate the plan while leaving equipment and safety decisions with the responsible specialists.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A spare part has an estimate, not a confirmed arrival

Separate fictional maintenance plan: a required spare part has an estimated Tuesday delivery; the carrier has not confirmed arrival, and the maintenance window is Wednesday.

01 · Maintenance scheduler: The spare part is estimated for Tuesday, ahead of Wednesday's window, but arrival isn't confirmed.

02 · Production manager: Can we commit to a Wednesday completion so I can promise Thursday output?

03 · Maintenance scheduler: That would depend on part receipt and the authorized maintenance assessment, neither settled by the estimate.

04 · Production manager: What conditional plan can we discuss with the team instead of leaving the whole schedule blank?

05 · Maintenance scheduler: Keep Wednesday as planned, subject to confirmed readiness, and agree when to review the part status.

06 · Production manager: Could a different part be substituted if the delivery slips by a day?

07 · Maintenance scheduler: Only through the appropriate technical approval; we shouldn't negotiate an unassessed substitution here.

08 · Production manager: I'll explain the dependency and request a delivery confirmation before the planning checkpoint.

09 · Maintenance scheduler: I'll coordinate readiness information and avoid treating a forecast arrival as a completed maintenance input.

10 · Production manager: Then we'll update output commitments from verified conditions rather than a chain of optimistic assumptions.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

Changeover timing with an unconfirmed extra order

Separate fictional planning case: a changeover is planned after order A; sales proposes adding order B first, but B's quantity and due date are unconfirmed.

01 · Sales coordinator: Could you delay the changeover and fit order B after A before switching products?

02 · Production scheduler: We can assess that, but B's quantity and required date haven't been confirmed.

03 · Sales coordinator: Keeping the current setup sounds efficient. Can we agree now and settle quantity later?

04 · Production scheduler: The benefit and impact depend on quantity, capacity, and the next scheduled order.

05 · Sales coordinator: What information would let you offer a useful tradeoff at the planning meeting?

06 · Production scheduler: Confirm B's scope and timing, then we can compare the changeover sequence and downstream commitments.

07 · Sales coordinator: I'll ask whether partial delivery is acceptable without promising that the line can provide it.

08 · Production scheduler: Good. We'll also retain any maintenance constraints rather than treat sequence flexibility as unlimited.

09 · Sales coordinator: I'll return the confirmed request before asking for a revised production commitment.

10 · Production scheduler: I'll assess the options with the responsible team and state the conditions attached to any feasible plan.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 05 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

A planned maintenance window conflicts with a rush order. The maintenance team needs to explain the available options to the decision maker.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You want the preferred outcome but can accept one tradeoff. Ask for two options, then state which condition you can accept and which still needs approval.

Second round: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

Model for scenario 1: The rush order and maintenance window compete for the same equipment. Could we review the approved options, expected production impact, and reliability concerns together before changing the plan?

Scenario 2 | A reliability average used to justify deferral

A fictional planning slide cites an equipment MTBF figure but gives no maintenance recommendation. A manager wants to use it to postpone a scheduled task. Practice explaining that mean time between failures is not itself authorization to defer work.

Role A: Maintenance planner: explain the distinction and request the authorized assessment.

Role B: Production manager: describe the schedule pressure and discuss conditional alternatives.

Possible opening: The MTBF figure summarizes reliability history; it does not by itself authorize postponing this task.

Success checks

- Do not convert an average into a no-failure promise.

- Keep maintenance authority with the responsible specialists.

- Agree to assess schedule options under explicit conditions.

Add a complication: The manager asks you to guarantee that nothing will fail during the delay.

LESSON 06 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An unclear isolation instruction before work begins

Fictional safety-communication exercise: an equipment-isolation instruction is ambiguous, no work has begun, and the local approved procedure must govern the task.

01 · Maintenance technician: This isolation instruction is unclear. I need the authorized supervisor to clarify it before the task proceeds.

02 · Safety supervisor: Which wording is ambiguous, and have you identified the approved procedure for this equipment?

03 · Maintenance technician: The instruction doesn't identify the equipment reference clearly. I won't guess the intended machine.

04 · Safety supervisor: Good. We need the correct reference and applicable lockout/tagout procedure, not an improvised interpretation.

05 · Maintenance technician: Can you take the clarification request and confirm who is authorized to resolve it?

06 · Safety supervisor: Yes. I'll coordinate that check through our local safety process.

07 · Maintenance technician: Should I treat a coworker's memory as a substitute while the document is checked?

08 · Safety supervisor: No. This exercise calls for clarification through the approved route before proceeding, not operational shortcuts.

09 · Maintenance technician: I'll keep the task pending and provide the exact instruction reference for review.

10 · Safety supervisor: Request received. I'll return the verified clarification and keep equipment decisions with the authorized team.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

A near-miss report needs the location clarified

Separate fictional EHS reporting exercise: a near miss is reported near a loading area, but the exact location is missing and no injury is reported in the supplied account.

01 · Warehouse supervisor: The report says near the loading area. Could you clarify the location before we route the follow-up?

02 · EHS coordinator: I'll request the specific location from the reporter and preserve the current account as incomplete.

03 · Warehouse supervisor: Can we enter bay four because it is the busiest bay on this shift?

04 · EHS coordinator: No. That would invent an event detail and could send the review to the wrong area.

05 · Warehouse supervisor: Please also confirm which responsible team should receive the report through our safety process.

06 · EHS coordinator: I will. The absence of an injury in the account doesn't remove the need for the reporting review.

07 · Warehouse supervisor: Should the briefing state that the area is now safe because the event ended?

08 · EHS coordinator: No assessment supporting that assurance is supplied here. Keep the known event separate from current safety status.

09 · Warehouse supervisor: I'll request a verified location and avoid adding a cause or safety conclusion.

10 · EHS coordinator: I'll acknowledge the handoff and arrange the appropriate follow-up under the local EHS process.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A stop-work concern needs a named receiver

Separate fictional safety drill: a technician raises a stop-work concern about conflicting task instructions, but no supervisor has acknowledged it; no operating steps are supplied.

01 · Technician: I've raised a stop-work concern about conflicting instructions, but I haven't received an acknowledgment.

02 · Shift supervisor: Please state the conflict clearly so I can receive the concern and route it appropriately.

03 · Technician: The two task sheets identify different equipment references. I need confirmation of the applicable instruction.

04 · Shift supervisor: Understood. We'll use the local approved process to resolve the conflict before the task proceeds.

05 · Technician: Can you confirm that you're accepting the clarification request, not simply noting that I called?

06 · Shift supervisor: Yes. I'll coordinate the authorized review and confirm the responsible decision maker.

07 · Technician: A colleague wants to choose the sheet with the newer print date. Is that verification?

08 · Shift supervisor: Not by itself. A print date doesn't establish which approved instruction governs this task.

09 · Technician: I'll preserve both references and keep the conflict visible in the handoff.

10 · Shift supervisor: Good. We'll return a verified instruction through the proper route rather than settle an equipment-safety question by guesswork.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 06 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | EHS and Safety Communication

During a safety exercise, a learner notices an unclear equipment-isolation instruction. The local approved procedure must govern the work.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You can help but need a clear request and its purpose. Ask what is required and whether the timing is fixed or negotiable.

Second round: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Model for scenario 1: I need clarification of this instruction before the task proceeds. Please involve the authorized person and use the approved safety procedure. I will point out exactly which instruction is unclear.

Scenario 2 | A safety notice with an unreadable equipment number

In a fictional safety exercise, a posted notice refers to an equipment number that cannot be read. A scheduled task may involve that equipment, but the match is unconfirmed. Request clarification through the local approved process before proceeding.

Role A: Maintenance technician: identify the unreadable reference and request an authorized check.

Role B: EHS supervisor: confirm receipt and arrange clarification without guessing the number.

Possible opening: I can't read the equipment reference on this notice, so I need confirmation before the scheduled task proceeds.

Success checks

- State the precise uncertainty.

- Do not infer the notice is irrelevant or give operational isolation steps.

- Confirm the authorized review route and receiving owner.

Add a complication: A colleague says the notice probably concerns another machine and suggests ignoring it.

LESSON 07 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

An inspection dimension without a drawing revision

Fictional supplier-quality call: an incoming report cites a dimension but omits the drawing revision; the supplier used a different revision.

01 · Supplier quality engineer: The incoming report cites a dimension without the drawing revision. Which specification was the inspection based on?

02 · Supplier representative: Our team used a different revision from the one your inspector mentioned verbally.

03 · Supplier quality engineer: Before discussing a deviation, we need the controlling requirement and both source references confirmed.

04 · Supplier representative: Could we accept the newer-looking drawing because it would resolve the disagreement quickly?

05 · Supplier quality engineer: Appearance or print date doesn't establish the controlling revision for this order.

06 · Supplier representative: I'll provide the drawing reference used for production and the order documentation available to us.

07 · Supplier quality engineer: I'll request the inspection source and verify the applicable specification through document control.

08 · Supplier representative: Should either team label the lot conforming or nonconforming before that clarification is complete?

09 · Supplier quality engineer: We shouldn't invent a conclusion from the conflicting references; disposition remains with the authorized quality process.

10 · Supplier representative: Agreed. We'll compare the verified requirement and measurement evidence before resolving the reported difference.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

Millimeters or inches on the supplier report?

Separate fictional incoming inspection: a supplier report lists a dimension as 2.5 without a unit; the receiving specification uses millimeters.

01 · Incoming inspector: Your report lists two point five but no unit. Could you confirm the measurement unit used?

02 · Supplier technician: I need to check the original record rather than assume it matches your millimeter specification.

03 · Incoming inspector: Thank you. A bare number doesn't let us compare the result reliably with the requirement.

04 · Supplier technician: Could you convert it as inches while I look for the record, just to keep inspection moving?

05 · Incoming inspector: No. That would base the assessment on an unverified unit and could change the conclusion.

06 · Supplier technician: I'll retrieve the source measurement and ask for a corrected report with the unit stated.

07 · Incoming inspector: Please include the applicable specification reference and drawing revision in that clarification.

08 · Supplier technician: Understood. I won't describe the lot as accepted just because the numerical value looks familiar.

09 · Incoming inspector: I'll keep the comparison pending and pass the verified information to the responsible quality reviewer.

10 · Supplier technician: I'll return the source-backed correction so the decision rests on the actual measurement rather than a guessed conversion.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A deviation request is not an approved exception

Separate fictional supplier discussion: a supplier submitted a deviation request for lot M6, but the receiving team has no approval record.

01 · Buyer: The supplier sent a deviation request for M6. Does that mean the specification exception is approved?

02 · Supplier quality lead: No. We have a request, but no verified authorization for the exception.

03 · Buyer: Which question should I ask before I give production an update on the lot?

04 · Supplier quality lead: Ask for the review status, the precise scope requested, and the responsible approval record if one exists.

05 · Buyer: Could we assume approval applies to future lots as well if M6 eventually receives it?

06 · Supplier quality lead: Not without the actual authorized scope. A specific exception shouldn't become a blanket specification change.

07 · Buyer: I'll distinguish requested from approved and keep the M6 reference in every status message.

08 · Supplier quality lead: Please also avoid treating supplier acknowledgment as confirmation from our quality decision maker.

09 · Buyer: I'll request the verified status and leave the material commitment conditional.

10 · Supplier quality lead: I'll review the returned information through the appropriate process and clarify any limits before the status is communicated further.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 07 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

An incoming inspection report cites a dimension without identifying the drawing revision. The supplier used a different revision.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Second round: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for scenario 1: Which drawing revision applies to this delivery? Let's record both references and ask the responsible quality team to resolve the discrepancy before we describe the material as conforming.

Scenario 2 | A certificate refers to the wrong order

A fictional incoming lot has a certificate naming purchase order 418, while the delivery paperwork names 481. The material identity has not been reconciled. Clarify the mismatch before using the certificate as evidence.

Role A: Incoming quality coordinator: identify the two order references and request verification.

Role B: Supplier documentation specialist: check the source records without assuming a typing error.

Possible opening: The certificate says 418 and the delivery says 481; could you verify which order this certificate supports?

Success checks

- State both references accurately.

- Do not assume a typographical error or alter supplier evidence informally.

- Agree a source-backed clarification and preserve lot traceability.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests changing the digits locally because the numbers look transposed.

LESSON 08 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 1 OF 3

Six checks complete, two handed over

Fictional shift handoff: six of eight checks are complete, check seven (label reconciliation) and check eight (container-count review) remain open, records are attached, and incoming supervisor Lee is the named receiver.

01 · Outgoing supervisor: Lee, six of the eight checks are complete. Two remain open, with the records attached.

02 · Incoming supervisor Lee: Which status should I communicate before I review the open items with the team?

03 · Outgoing supervisor: Six complete, two pending. Don't describe the checklist as finished or imply an authorized production decision.

04 · Incoming supervisor Lee: Do the attached records identify the open checks, or do I need another source?

05 · Outgoing supervisor: Check seven is label reconciliation; check eight is container-count review. Both are open, with supporting records attached.

06 · Incoming supervisor Lee: I'll take ownership of reviewing the two open items and confirming the appropriate next action.

07 · Outgoing supervisor: Please read back the completion count so we know the transfer is clear.

08 · Incoming supervisor Lee: Six complete; label reconciliation and container-count review remain open. I own their follow-up.

09 · Outgoing supervisor: Correct. Any concern needing escalation should follow our established route rather than remain only in this conversation.

10 · Incoming supervisor Lee: Handoff accepted. I'll confirm the verified status after reviewing the records with the responsible team.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 2 OF 3

An andon call acknowledged but unresolved

Separate fictional shift handoff: an andon call for line C was acknowledged at 13:40, but no resolution is recorded; incoming line leader Noor will follow up.

01 · Outgoing line leader: Line C's andon call was acknowledged at thirteen forty, but no resolution is recorded.

02 · Incoming line leader Noor: So acknowledgment tells us someone received the call, not that the underlying issue is resolved?

03 · Outgoing line leader: Exactly. Please keep those two statuses separate when you brief the incoming team.

04 · Incoming line leader Noor: Do we have enough information to say why the line raised the call?

05 · Outgoing line leader: The reason isn't supplied in this handoff summary. You'll need the actual call record to verify it.

06 · Incoming line leader Noor: I'll own that follow-up and confirm the responsible responder through the escalation process.

07 · Outgoing line leader: Please don't mark the issue closed merely because the alert has been acknowledged.

08 · Incoming line leader Noor: Understood: line C, acknowledgment at thirteen forty, resolution unconfirmed, follow-up assigned to me.

09 · Outgoing line leader: That's correct. I'll remain available to clarify the outgoing shift's documented actions.

10 · Incoming line leader Noor: I'll return the verified status and pass any unresolved concern through the appropriate escalation route.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 05 · CONVERSATIONS / 3 OF 3

A quality hold must survive the shift change

Separate fictional handoff: pallet P9 remains on quality hold; investigation is pending, and no release has been authorized. Incoming warehouse supervisor Chen receives the handoff.

01 · Outgoing warehouse supervisor: Pallet P9 remains on quality hold. Investigation is pending, and no release is authorized.

02 · Incoming supervisor Chen: The dispatch list includes P9. Does being on that list change the hold status?

03 · Outgoing warehouse supervisor: No. A planned dispatch entry isn't a quality release or a change in disposition.

04 · Incoming supervisor Chen: I'll flag the conflict to dispatch and maintain the verified hold status through our process.

05 · Outgoing warehouse supervisor: Please confirm who will seek the next quality update so the issue has a clear owner.

06 · Incoming supervisor Chen: I'll own that follow-up and contact the responsible quality team for a verified status.

07 · Outgoing warehouse supervisor: Don't infer release from silence if the team hasn't responded before the truck arrives.

08 · Incoming supervisor Chen: Understood. P9 remains held, and the dispatch conflict needs escalation if unresolved.

09 · Outgoing warehouse supervisor: That's the handoff. The record reference is P9, and I haven't promised an investigation outcome.

10 · Incoming supervisor Chen: Accepted. I'll communicate the confirmed status and keep dispatch planning separate from release authority.

Notice, then rehearse

Name each speaker's purpose. Identify one useful expression and the next step or unresolved question. Read the roles aloud, then switch roles.

LESSON 08 / 06 · SAY IT

Two scenarios to practice

Use only the supplied facts. Prepare for two minutes, speak for one minute, then respond to a follow-up. Switch roles and repeat. For solo study, speak both roles aloud.

Scenario 1 | Shift Handoffs and Escalation

The outgoing shift has completed six of eight checks. Two checks remain open, with records attached and a named incoming supervisor.

Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You are taking over the work. Ask what remains open and repeat back the critical status or responsibility. Point out one detail that would be unsafe or misleading to assume.

Second round: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

Model for scenario 1: Six checks are complete; two remain open. The records show what has been checked and what is pending. Please confirm that the incoming supervisor has accepted the follow-up tasks.

Scenario 2 | An unfinished count handed to the next shift

A fictional shift counted 70 of 100 containers. Thirty remain unchecked, and no discrepancy has yet been established. Incoming supervisor Rosa is the named receiver. Practice transferring the count status and follow-up responsibility.

Role A: Outgoing supervisor: state the checked and unchecked quantities without declaring the inventory reconciled.

Role B: Incoming supervisor Rosa: read back the remaining work and accept the next count-status update.

Possible opening: Seventy containers are checked; thirty remain, so the count is not yet complete.

Success checks

- Distinguish unchecked from missing.

- Read back seventy complete and thirty pending.

- Confirm Rosa's follow-up ownership without predicting the final count result.

Add a complication: A planner asks you to classify the thirty unchecked containers as missing.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

Open this course's AI prompt workshop

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Rehearse with an AI colleague

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Manufacturing English

Professional audience: plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals

Scope: These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Dialogue 01: Morning tier meeting

Original fictional setting: The packaging line has missed its hourly production target.

Professional roles: Production supervisor / Line leader / Maintenance technician

Published dialogue (reference script, not my own performance):

Production supervisor: We're 160 units behind plan. Where are we losing time?

Line leader: At the case sealer. We've had four short stops since startup.

Maintenance technician: Is it the same fault code each time?

Line leader: Yes, the infeed sensor. Operators logged each stop on the downtime sheet.

Production supervisor: Can we recover the schedule without adding a second shift?

Maintenance technician: I need to inspect the sensor under the approved isolation procedure before estimating downtime.

Line leader: I'll separate the affected cases and update the hour-by-hour board.

Production supervisor: Good. Maintenance owns the fault check; I'll revise the production plan after your assessment.

Vocabulary in this exchange: downtime: Time during which equipment or a service is unavailable for its intended work.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Interactive workplace role-play

1. Use the supplied case or dialogue as the starting situation. Give a two-sentence briefing and offer two relevant professional roles for me to choose from. For a supplied dialogue, use its actual roles. Ask which role I want, then stop and wait. Do not write my replies.

2. After I choose, identify who you will play and the immediate communication goal. Play the other professional; where a meeting requires a third person, label each of your speakers clearly. Start with one natural workplace turn and wait for my reply. Keep most turns to one to three sentences and ask no more than one question at a time.

3. Let the exchange develop across six to ten learner turns, or end earlier if I type "feedback". Respond to what I actually say. Include a plausible clarification, disagreement or tradeoff without silently changing the starting facts. Mark any added constraint as a fictional second-round variation. Do not resolve approvals, evidence or commitments that remain uncertain.

4. Stay in role during the exchange. If my meaning is unclear, ask for clarification naturally. Give a hint only if I ask or cannot proceed. Do not deliver a model conversation in advance.

5. At the debrief, quote two of my phrases: one successful choice and one worth improving. Check factual accuracy, language, register and whether the next step was clear. Give up to three focused suggestions. Ask me to retry the weakest turn; wait. Only then offer an alternative wording and a harder replay.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Create more scenario dialogues

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

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Production supervisor: Good. Maintenance owns the fault check; I'll revise the production plan after your assessment.

Vocabulary in this exchange: downtime: Time during which equipment or a service is unavailable for its intended work.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Extend the conversation library

1. Propose six distinct, common scenarios in this field beyond the supplied case or script. For each, name the setting, two or more professional roles, the communication problem and one useful terminology focus. Include routine coordination, clarification, a complication, disagreement, handoff and follow-up where relevant. Choose scenarios that fit this profession, rather than forcing unsuitable situations into it.

2. Ask me to choose one scenario, or request all six in sequence. Stop and wait. Do not write all the scripts before I choose.

3. For the selected scenario, write an original fictional dialogue of 12-18 substantial speaking turns between two or three professionals. Name each role, establish an actual work problem, and let the exchange progress through questions, clarification, competing constraints and a credible next step or explicitly unresolved issue. Use the occupation's natural nomenclature and register. Avoid an interview between a teacher and a learner, generic small talk, and inserting a glossary definition into every reply. Explain specialist terms outside the dialogue instead.

4. After the script, explain five useful expressions in context, identify two grammar or register choices and ask three questions about the speakers' reasoning. Withhold the answers until I attempt them. Add one role-switch challenge.

5. Before presenting a script, check names, numbers, chronology, roles and terminology for consistency. Label invented facts and acknowledge uncertain specialist usage. If I requested all six, deliver one complete script at a time and wait for "next". Make each scenario materially different.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level